

General Jeb Stuart and his Confederate cavalry received a nasty shock from their Union counterparts. On June 9, at Brandy Station in Culpeper County, Virginia, a large Union cavalry force under the command of General Alfred Pleasonton surprised Stuart's troopers in their encampment. Following a hard day's fighting in which both sides gained the upper hand at different times, the Union cavalry finally yielded the battlefield to the Southerners and withdrew. Tactically, the engagement was the largest horse-mounted combat of the Civil War and a Confederate triumph—strategically, it assumed far greater proportions.

Union horsemen had gained confidence from it, believing that they could now stand toe-to-toe against the Southern cavaliers. Henceforth they would be more aggressive. Stuart emerged from the battle physically unscathed but with a bruised ego. He asked Lee for permission to ride around Major General Joseph Hooker's corps slowly advancing to the east—Stuart's goal was to gain better intelligence on Union movements, but in the process he hoped to salvage his reputation.

907 The number of Union casualties during the cavalry battle at Brandy Station in Virginia, on June 9, 1863. Confederate casualties numbered 523, and it was the first time Jeb Stuart's leadership was criticized.